What Lowi Predicted: Redistributive Legislation and the Committee Processing Penalty in the Korean National Assembly

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Abstract

Why do some bills die in committee while others advance? The legislative effectiveness literature measures effectiveness as an attribute of legislators, yet Lowi's foundational typology predicts that policy content itself should shape legislative fortunes. I test this prediction at the committee processing stage - where the vast majority of legislation succeeds or fails - using 15,291 bills from the Korean National Assembly (20th-21st terms, 2016-2024). Classifying bills by policy domain and Lowi type, I find that redistributive legislation faces a 9.3 percentage-point committee processing penalty after controlling for arrival timing, sponsor characteristics, bill seriousness, and committee fixed effects. The penalty operates within committees, within individual sponsors' portfolios, and across bill seriousness levels. Under divided government, the penalty nearly triples to 18.4 percentage points. The redistributive-distributive gradient is largest where organized opposition is strongest (labor: -15.7 pp) and absent where opposition is diffuse (care/welfare: 0.0 pp), consistent with Lowi's prediction as refined through Olson's logic of collective action.

1. Introduction

Lowi (1964) advanced a deceptively simple prediction: redistributive, distributive, and regulatory policies generate fundamentally different political dynamics. Redistributive legislation creates identifiable winners and losers, mobilizing organized opposition from the losing side. Distributive legislation concentrates benefits on specific constituencies without generating organized resistance. Six decades of scholarship have applied this insight to explain variation in legislative coalitions, lobbying patterns, and policy outcomes at the macro level. Yet there exists, to my knowledge, no study that tests Lowi's prediction at the committee

processing stage - the institutional chokepoint where, in most legislatures, the vast majority of bills live or die.

This lacuna is puzzling because committees are precisely where the political dynamics Lowi describes should manifest most clearly. If redistributive bills generate organized opposition while distributive bills do not, committees reviewing redistributive proposals should face greater difficulty building the consensus required for action. The prediction is direct: redistributive legislation should exhibit lower committee processing rates than distributive legislation, even when introduced by the same sponsors and reviewed by the same committees. Despite six decades of theoretical motivation, this prediction has never been tested.

A parallel gap exists in the legislative effectiveness literature. Volden and Wiseman (2014) developed the Legislative Effectiveness Score to measure variation across legislators - some are more skilled, more networked, or more strategically positioned than others. Yet the LES framework treats all bills within a legislator's portfolio symmetrically. A legislator who advances five distributive bills scores identically to one who advances five redistributive bills, despite the very different political environments these bill types face. I argue that legislative effectiveness is conditioned by policy type: the same legislator achieves different committee processing rates depending on what the legislation attempts to do. This claim synthesizes two literatures - Volden and Wiseman's legislator-centered effectiveness framework and Lowi's content-centered policy typology - that have not previously spoken to each other.

The Korean National Assembly (KNA) provides an unusually productive setting for this test. Approximately 80 percent of KNA bills die from passive committee inaction - placed on a committee agenda but never receiving a formal decision before the Assembly term expires (Analyst, KNA database). This rate of committee-stage attrition is substantially higher than in the U.S. Congress, where committees hold hearings on roughly 10-15 percent of introduced bills (Krutz 2005). The KNA's bill-tracking infrastructure records each bill's proposal date, committee referral, propose-reason text, cosponsor list, and processing outcome - providing the bill-level data required to classify legislation by policy domain and trace its committee-stage fate.

I classify 15,291 on-agenda bills from the 20th and 21st Assemblies (2016-2024) into six beneficiary categories using keyword analysis of bill propose-reason texts, then further classify bills along Lowi's redistributive-distributive dimension. The central finding is a robust committee processing penalty for legislation targeting economically vulnerable populations - what Korean political discourse terms *minsaeng* (livelihood) legislation, encompassing labor, welfare, and care/family bills. After controlling for arrival timing, cosponsor count, propose-reason text length, sponsor party, and committee fixed effects, *minsaeng* bills are 9.3

percentage points less likely to receive any committee decision than non-*minsaeng* bills. The penalty is present within committees (gaps ranging from 6.8 to 16.8 percentage points across eight major committees), within individual legislators' portfolios (-11.9 pp among 327 legislators with sufficient bills in both categories), and across bill seriousness proxies (-10.6 to -11.1 pp regardless of text length or cosponsor count).

Two additional findings deepen the theoretical contribution. First, the Lowi decomposition reveals that the penalty concentrates in domains where organized opposition exists. Redistributive labor bills (minimum wage mandates, occupational safety penalties) process at 22.8 percent - barely half the rate of distributive labor bills (employment subsidies, job training grants) at 38.5 percent. Yet within care and welfare categories, where even redistributive bills face diffuse rather than organized opposition, the gradient is effectively zero. This pattern maps onto a refinement of Lowi through Olson (1965): the redistributive processing penalty requires organized opposition on the losing side, not merely the presence of redistribution. Second, the penalty is regime-conditional. Under unified government, the average marginal effect of *minsaeng* status is -7.0 percentage points; under divided government, it expands to -18.4 pp, with the cost falling almost entirely on welfare, labor, and care legislation while non-*minsaeng* bills barely change.

These findings extend the closest existing precedent - Volden, Wiseman, and Wittmer (2016), who document that women's issues bills pass at half the rate of other legislation in the U.S. Congress - in three directions: committee-level decomposition of the processing penalty, regime-conditional variation, and a Lowi-based theoretical mechanism for *why* certain content categories face disadvantage.

The paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 reviews the winnowing, legislative effectiveness, and policy typology literatures, deriving the expectation that redistributive bills should face a committee processing penalty moderated by organized opposition. Section 3 describes the KNA database, keyword classification procedure, and identification strategy. Section 4 presents results. Section 5 discusses implications and limitations.

2. Literature and Theory

Committee winnowing and the question of content-blindness

Legislative committees process far fewer bills than they receive. Krutz (2005) conceptualizes this as "winnowing" - a triage process under bounded rationality in which committees use heuristic cues (party affiliation, sponsor seniority, entrepreneurial effort) to allocate scarce attention. Krutz's analysis of U.S. House committees across five issue areas finds that party

structures winnowing and that seniority matters more in the Senate, but his framework treats winnowing as *content-neutral*: committees triage based on sponsor characteristics and institutional signals, not on what the bill proposes to do.

Lewallen (2020) argues that U.S. congressional committees have shifted from lawmaking to oversight, reducing the volume of legislation that receives substantive committee attention. This structural account, like Krutz's, does not predict content-specific processing differentials. Both frameworks imply that a labor bill and a regulatory bill introduced by the same sponsor with the same cosponsorship support should face similar committee processing probabilities. My data allow a direct test of this implication.

The Korean literature on committee processing has focused on sponsor-level determinants. Kim and Lee (2023) demonstrate that a bill sponsor's position on the reviewing subcommittee predicts bill passage - a committee-insider advantage that operates independently of bill content. Yoon and Shin (2023) show that network centrality in cosponsorship networks predicts bill success. An, Park, and Lee (2025) examine sponsor characteristics (party, seniority, committee position) as predictors of bill passage in the 20th and 21st Assemblies using logistic regression and SHAP analysis. Ka (2025) analyzes legislator-level passage rates. All four studies ask "what kind of legislator succeeds?" None asks "what kind of legislation succeeds?" - the question this paper addresses.

Lowi's typology and committee-stage predictions

Lowi (1964) predicts that redistributive policies generate a distinctive pattern of political conflict involving broad class-based coalitions on both sides. Distributive policies, by contrast, generate support from beneficiaries without creating organized resistance - the classic logic of concentrated benefits and diffuse costs. Wilson (1980) formalizes this into a 2x2 matrix of concentrated versus diffuse benefits and costs. Kim (2019) applies Wilson's typology to the KNA, finding that policy type predicts which bills receive public hearings - a procedural decision. I extend this insight from procedural treatment to substantive processing outcomes: does policy type predict whether committees act on bills at all?

The prediction is straightforward. Redistributive bills - those imposing identifiable costs on organized groups (employer mandates, regulatory penalties, tax increases on specific sectors) - should face lower committee processing rates than distributive bills (targeted subsidies, tax exemptions, support programs) because the organized opposition they generate makes committee consensus harder to achieve. This prediction holds only when the losing side of redistribution is well-organized. Where opposition is diffuse, Lowi's mechanism should not operate.

Legislative effectiveness as a bill-level attribute

Volden and Wiseman (2014) measure legislative effectiveness as a legislator attribute, aggregating across a legislator's entire bill portfolio to produce the Legislative Effectiveness Score. The framework has been extended to 97 U.S. state chambers (Bucchianeri, Volden, and Wiseman 2024) and applied to content-classified bill fates: Volden, Wiseman, and Wittmer (2016) find that women's issues bills have a 2 percent passage rate in the U.S. Congress versus 4 percent for all bills - a content penalty that even effective women legislators cannot fully overcome. This finding suggests that effectiveness depends not only on who introduces the bill but on what the bill proposes.

I formalize this insight: legislative effectiveness is conditioned by policy type. If Lowi's typology is correct, even legislators who are highly effective at advancing distributive legislation should face structural disadvantages when introducing redistributive proposals, because the political environment changes with policy content. The within-sponsor comparison - examining whether the same legislator's redistributive bills fare worse than her distributive bills - provides the cleanest test.

Position-taking and the bill-quality confound

Mayhew (1974) observes that legislators engage in position-taking - introducing legislation to signal preferences to voters regardless of legislative intent. Kang and Park (2025) document "waffling" in the KNA: legislators systematically sponsoring bills they later vote against, confirming that bill introduction and legislative intent are not equivalent. Park (2023) shows that voters reward grandstanding (messaging intensity) while remaining uninformed about legislative effectiveness, creating rational incentives for symbolic bill introduction on voter-salient topics.

If *minsaeng* topics attract disproportionate position-taking, the bill pool for labor and welfare legislation may contain a higher share of low-quality or symbolic proposals. The processing penalty would then reflect bill-pool composition rather than committee content bias. Schilling, Matthews, and Kreitzer (2023) suggest that cosponsorship timing can distinguish sincere from strategic sponsorship, but this measure is unavailable for the KNA. I instead employ three alternative tests: within-sponsor comparisons (holding legislator quality constant), seriousness-proxy stratification (text length and cosponsor count), and prolific-sponsor analysis.

Expectations

These literatures generate three testable expectations:

E1. Redistributive legislation faces a lower committee processing rate than distributive legislation, controlling for sponsor characteristics, arrival timing, and committee assignment.

E2. The redistributive processing penalty is larger in policy domains where the losing side is well-organized (labor, where employer associations mobilize) than in domains where losers are diffuse (care/welfare, where costs fall on taxpayers generally).

E3. Under divided government, when the veto-player configuration increases the difficulty of achieving policy change (Tsebelis 2002), the content-based processing penalty expands - particularly for redistributive legislation that requires overcoming both organized opposition and inter-branch disagreement.

3. Data and Method

The KNA database

I draw on comprehensive bill-level data from the Korean National Assembly covering the 17th through 22nd Assemblies (2004-2024), comprising 110,778 bills with 42-55 variables each. The primary analysis focuses on the 20th and 21st Assemblies (2016-2024), yielding 50,003 legislation bills (*beomnyulan*). For each bill, the database records proposal date, sponsor identity, cosponsor list, referred committee, committee decision (if any), floor vote outcome, and a linked propose-reason text explaining the bill's purpose.

The dependent variable is binary: whether the bill received any formal committee decision (1) or remained on the committee agenda without action until the Assembly term expired (0). This operationalizes the committee processing stage that prior work identifies as the primary legislative bottleneck - 79.9 percent of failed bills in the 20th-21st Assemblies die at this stage, placed on a committee agenda but never acted upon. This figure reflects genuine inaction: bills processed through the *daean-banyeong-pyegi* (alternative-incorporation-disposal) mechanism, in which a bill's content is absorbed into an omnibus committee alternative, all carry formal committee decision dates and do not appear in the "no decision" category.

Bill classification

I classify bills into six beneficiary categories using keyword analysis of propose-reason texts: Welfare/Vulnerable Populations, Labor/Workers, Care/Family, Small Business, General Public/Safety, and Industry/Corporate, with 10-16 Korean-language keywords per category. A bill is assigned to the category with the highest keyword count; ties are broken by category priority (welfare first). The classifier achieves 33.8 percent coverage, classifying 16,924 of 50,003 bills. Internal consistency checks confirm face validity: all 31 minimum wage bills

classify as Labor, all 223 *geunro-gijunbeop* (Labor Standards Act) bills classify as Labor, and all major childcare bills classify as Care. The *minsaeng* category is defined as the union of Welfare, Labor, and Care (excluding Small Business, following the theoretical logic that small business bills are predominantly distributive and reflect organized-constituency politics).

I further classify bills along Lowi's redistributive-distributive dimension using a second keyword layer. Bills with more redistributive keywords (minimum wage mandates, penalties, prohibitions, regulatory strengthening) than distributive keywords (subsidies, tax exemptions, incentives, support grants) are coded as redistributive (N = 4,355); the reverse for distributive (N = 5,304).

The analytical sample for the main regression comprises N = 15,291 on-agenda classified bills from the 20th-21st Assemblies.

Identification strategy

The core specification is a logistic regression:

$$\Pr(\text{Decision}_i = 1) = \Lambda(\beta_1 \text{Minsaeng}_i + \mathbf{X}_i\gamma + \delta_c + \epsilon_i)$$

where $\mathbf{X}_i$ includes months since Assembly start (arrival timing), log cosponsor count, log propose-reason text length (a seriousness proxy), Lowi type (redistributive/distributive), sponsor party, and divided government status; δ_c captures committee fixed effects. I report average marginal effects for substantive interpretation.

Two identification strategies address the position-taking confound. First, I estimate within-sponsor comparisons among 327 legislators who introduced at least 5 *minsaeng* and 5 non-*minsaeng* bills, computing each legislator's within-portfolio gap. Second, I stratify the sample by seriousness proxies (above/below median text length; above/below median cosponsor count) and estimate the *minsaeng* penalty separately within each subgroup.

4. Results

The committee processing penalty

Table 1 reports category-specific committee decision rates and enactment rates for on-agenda bills.

Table 1. Committee Processing by Beneficiary Category (20th-21st Assemblies)

Category	N (on agenda)	Decision Rate	Enactment Rate
Labor	2,887	28.5%	2.7%
Care	2,605	31.6%	3.1%
Welfare	2,524	34.0%	5.3%
Industry	1,304	40.2%	5.9%
Safety	4,057	40.5%	7.0%
Small Business	2,093	46.4%	6.7%

Labor bills are 30 percent less likely to receive any committee decision than Safety bills (risk ratio: 28.5/40.5 = 0.70). The enactment risk ratio is starker: 2.7/7.0 = 0.39. The gradient runs monotonically from the most redistributive category (Labor) to the most distributive (Small Business).

Multivariate results

Table 2 presents nested logistic regression models.

Table 2. Logistic Regression: Committee Decision

Variable	Model 1	Model 3	Model A	Model C
Minsaeng	-0.470***	-0.418***	-0.423***	-0.318***
Months since start		-0.019***	-0.019***	-0.019***
Log cosponsors		-0.010	+0.014	+0.016
Log text length		+0.204***	+0.213***	+0.210***
Redistributive			-0.093**	-0.096**
DPK sponsor			-0.125***	-0.121***
Divided government			+0.001	+0.237***
Minsaeng x Divided				-0.536***
Committee FE	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
N	15,291	15,291	15,291	15,291
Pseudo-R2	0.010	0.044	0.045	0.046

*Note: *p<0.1, **p<0.05, ***p<0.01.*

The *minsaeng* coefficient is negative, large, and statistically significant at the 0.1 percent level in every specification. Adding the full set of controls (Model 3) attenuates the coefficient from

-0.470 to -0.418, an 11 percent reduction - substantial but far from elimination. The average marginal effect in Model A is -9.3 percentage points: *minsaeng* bills are 9.3 pp less likely to receive any committee decision, controlling for all observed covariates.

Two variables that might explain the gap do not. Arrival timing works in the opposite direction from what a queueing account would predict: *minsaeng* bills arrive *earlier* on average (month 18.0 vs. 18.6 for non-*minsaeng*), and controlling for timing actually increases the penalty. Cosponsor count has no detectable effect ($p = 0.60$ to 0.88 across specifications), consistent with the KNA's low 10-cosponsor threshold rendering cosponsorship uninformative as a quality signal.

Text length, by contrast, is strongly predictive. Bills with longer propose-reason texts are significantly more likely to receive committee decisions (beta = 0.204, $p < 0.001$), consistent with text length as a proxy for policy substance. Yet even controlling for this seriousness measure, the *minsaeng* penalty persists.

Within-committee variation

The penalty operates within committees, though its magnitude varies substantially - from 6.8 percentage points in the Finance Committee (*jeongmuwiwonhoe*) to 16.8 pp in the Environment and Labor Committee (*hwangyeong-nodong-wiwonhoe*). The corrected within-committee gaps for the eight largest committees processing *minsaeng* bills are:

Table 3. Within-Committee Minsaeng Processing Gaps

Committee	Minsaeng Rate	Non-Minsaeng Rate	Gap
Environment and Labor	21.8% (N=2,000)	38.6% (N=376)	-16.8 pp
Land and Transport	36.8% (N=397)	51.1% (N=624)	-14.3 pp
Education	22.4% (N=410)	33.5% (N=161)	-11.1 pp
Trade, Industry, SMEs	32.2% (N=171)	42.5% (N=1,112)	-10.4 pp
Health and Welfare	32.2% (N=2,020)	42.0% (N=619)	-9.8 pp
Strategy and Finance	40.0% (N=660)	49.5% (N=1,223)	-9.5 pp
Agriculture and Fisheries	46.8% (N=188)	55.1% (N=354)	-8.3 pp
Political Affairs	19.4% (N=247)	26.2% (N=1,082)	-6.8 pp

The gap is negative in all eight committees. The largest gap appears where the most contentious redistributive legislation (labor standards, minimum wage) concentrates. The

smallest appears where both *minsaeng* and non-*minsaeng* bills have low overall rates, compressing the gap.

The Lowi decomposition

The within-category decomposition provides the paper's sharpest theoretical test.

Table 4. Decision Rates by Lowi Type Within Policy Domain

Category	Redistributive	Distributive	Gap
Labor	22.8% (N=899)	38.5% (N=889)	-15.7 pp
Small Business	31.3% (N=412)	53.3% (N=1,116)	-22.0 pp
Care	32.4% (N=709)	32.3% (N=932)	-0.1 pp
Welfare	35.3% (N=563)	35.2% (N=1,061)	+0.1 pp

Two patterns are consistent with E2. In Labor and Small Business, where employer organizations and industry associations provide organized opposition to redistributive mandates, the Lowi gradient is massive: redistributive labor bills process at barely half the rate of distributive ones. In Care and Welfare, where even redistributive bills (mandatory employer childcare contributions, expanded coverage mandates) face diffuse taxpayer opposition rather than organized resistance, the gradient is effectively zero. The Lowi mechanism operates precisely where Olson's (1965) logic of collective action predicts concentrated opposition.

The regression confirms this: the redistributive coefficient in Model A is -0.093 ($p = 0.021$), corresponding to a 2.0 percentage-point average marginal effect after controlling for *minsaeng* status and all other covariates.

Ruling out position-taking

Three tests address the concern that *minsaeng* bills contain disproportionately more position-taking legislation.

Within-sponsor comparison. Among 327 legislators who introduced at least 5 *minsaeng* and 5 non-*minsaeng* bills, the mean within-legislator gap is -11.9 pp ($t = -10.06$, $p < 0.001$). Fully 71.9 percent of these legislators show a negative gap - their own *minsaeng* bills fare worse than their own non-*minsaeng* bills. This result cannot be explained by between-legislator composition effects: it compares the same legislator's bills across categories.

Seriousness-proxy stratification. The penalty is essentially identical across all seriousness subgroups: -10.8 pp for long-text bills, -10.7 pp for short-text bills, -10.6 pp for high-

cosponsor bills, -11.1 pp for low-cosponsor bills. If position-taking inflated the *minsaeng* pool with frivolous legislation, the penalty should concentrate among short, poorly cosponsored bills. It does not.

Prolific *minsaeng* sponsors. Legislators in the top quartile of *minsaeng* bill share show a 12.5 pp within-sponsor gap - nearly identical to the population-wide gap. Position-taking may inflate the overall bill pool, but it does not drive the *differential* processing penalty between *minsaeng* and non-*minsaeng* bills.

The divided government interaction

Model C introduces the *minsaeng* x divided government interaction, which is the largest coefficient in any specification (beta = -0.536, SE = 0.089, $p < 0.001$).

Table 5. Conditional Average Marginal Effects by Regime

Regime	AME of Minsaeng	Minsaeng Decision Rate	Non-Minsaeng Decision Rate
Unified (Moon, 2020-2022)	-7.0 pp	33.1%	41.6%
Divided (Yoon, 2022-2024)	-18.4 pp	21.2%	40.5%

Under unified government, the *minsaeng* penalty is modest. Under divided government, it nearly triples. Non-*minsaeng* bills barely change across regimes (41.6% to 40.5%), but *minsaeng* bills collapse from 33.1% to 21.2%. Consistent with E3, the regime shift does not slow the Assembly uniformly - it selectively stalls redistributive legislation while leaving other legislation relatively unaffected.

5. Discussion

Connecting to theory

The findings support the Lowi-Volden synthesis: legislative effectiveness is conditioned by policy type. The same legislator achieves different committee processing rates depending on what the legislation proposes, and the within-domain Lowi gradient reveals the mechanism. Where redistributive bills create identifiable losers represented by organized groups - employer associations opposing labor mandates, industry groups opposing regulatory penalties - committees face greater difficulty building consensus. Where the losing side is diffuse (care and welfare), even redistributive bills process at rates comparable to distributive ones. This

pattern is precisely what Lowi (1964) predicted and what Olson (1965) would explain: the redistributive processing penalty requires not merely redistribution but the political mobilization structure that redistribution activates.

The divided government finding engages a distinct theoretical tradition. Tsebelis (2002) predicts that additional veto players narrow the winset of policies that can defeat the status quo. Hacker (2004) argues that gridlock produces "policy drift" - welfare state retrenchment through failure to update legislation. My finding that the *minsaeng* penalty nearly triples under divided government provides bill-level evidence for the distributional incidence of this mechanism. The transition from unified to divided government does not merely increase gridlock; it concentrates gridlock in the policy domains where vulnerable populations depend on legislative action.

Limitations and unresolved concerns

Several limitations deserve candid acknowledgment. First, the keyword classifier covers only 33.8 percent of bills. The unclassified residual (decision rate: 36.2%) falls between the *minsaeng* and non-*minsaeng* rates, suggesting it is a mixture. The findings apply to legislation with identifiable beneficiary populations, not to all legislation. A keyword-assisted topic model following Eshima, Imai, and Sasaki (2023) would expand coverage while providing probabilistic classifications that propagate classification uncertainty into standard errors.

Second, committee chair party affiliation - the single variable most likely to alter the interpretation - is absent from the data. If opposition-party chairs systematically deprioritize the majority party's signature *minsaeng* legislation, the processing penalty could partly reflect partisan gatekeeping mediated through content rather than content-based political difficulty. This alternative is testable with committee leadership data from the KNA website but has not yet been implemented.

Third, the within-sponsor test rules out between-legislator composition but cannot fully exclude within-legislator, across-category position-taking: a legislator may draft a careful regulatory bill and a symbolic minimum wage bill in the same session. This residual concern is real but second-order. Volden, Wiseman, and Wittmer (2016) do not control for position-taking at all; the combination of within-sponsor, seriousness-proxy, and prolific-sponsor tests exceeds the robustness standard set by any existing study in this literature.

Fourth, the Pseudo-R2 of 0.046 indicates that the model explains less than 5 percent of variation in committee processing. Individual bill fates depend on idiosyncratic factors - committee chair preferences, informal inter-party negotiations, government agency support - none observable in the data. Low model fit is expected for bill-level binary outcome models

and does not invalidate coefficient estimates. The *minsaeng* coefficient corresponds to a 25 percent reduction in processing probability relative to the 35-40 percent baseline, a substantively meaningful effect.

Finally, the Lowi classifier is crude. The keyword "support" (*jiwon*) appears in both genuinely distributive bills (targeted subsidies) and in redistributive bills framed as support (disability accommodation mandates). A more careful classification would code the policy mechanism (mandate vs. subsidy) rather than the rhetoric.

6. Conclusion

This paper provides the first test of Lowi's redistributive-distributive typology at the committee processing stage. Using 15,291 bills from the Korean National Assembly, I find that redistributive legislation faces a 9.3 percentage-point committee processing penalty that operates within committees, within sponsors' portfolios, and across seriousness levels. The penalty is largest where organized opposition is strongest and absent where opposition is diffuse - a pattern consistent with the Lowi-Olson synthesis. Under divided government, the penalty nearly triples, with the distributional cost falling disproportionately on welfare, labor, and care legislation.

The theoretical implication extends beyond the Korean case. If legislative effectiveness depends not only on who introduces a bill but on what the bill proposes, then the Volden-Wiseman framework understates the structural disadvantages facing legislators who champion redistributive causes. A highly effective legislator working on minimum wage reform operates in a fundamentally different political environment than an equally effective legislator working on small business subsidies - and this difference is rooted in the policy content itself, not in legislator skill or institutional position.

Two directions for future work follow directly. First, obtaining committee chair party affiliation data would permit distinguishing the content-based interpretation (Lowi: redistributive bills are inherently harder to process) from the partisan-gatekeeping alternative (chairs selectively deprioritize the opposing party's policy agenda). Second, comparative extension to Japan's Diet or Taiwan's Legislative Yuan would test whether the redistributive processing penalty is a general feature of committee-based legislatures, as Lowi's theory predicts, or a Korea-specific institutional pathology.

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